laments that the ASI folks often take shortcuts with restoration work, such as using cement instead of lime mortar.

‘We need to be proud of our culture and heritage,’ Krishna says. I wonder who his ‘we’ seeks to include and exclude, which soon becomes apparent. He strongly disagrees with those who idolize the West as a model for India. ‘Our society was once great,’ he says. ‘What we have lately become is due to the Mughals and the British. We were not so corrupt back then,’ he says. ‘Our class divisions were once based on merit and aptitude; now, sadly, we have hereditary caste, Brahmin pride, reservations, and all that stupid stuff. We were much better, and we need to go back and reclaim that past, while avoiding the mistakes of that age.’ I wonder what ‘mistakes’ he has in mind and how far back he wants to go, but he continues, ‘We need to cultivate more pride in our own history and achievements. Here in the south, for instance, why should we read about the Mughals and the Delhi Sultanate? Our history books, he asserts, contain so little about Vijayanagar, and only praise the Mughals and the British, even though we were better. We had a great civilization and we built amazing cities like Vijayanagar. We need to tell our own stories, because, as that famous African proverb goes, until the story of the hunt is told by the lion, the tale of the hunt will always glorify the hunter.’ The irony escapes him that for centuries his ancestors, running a powerful empire, were the proverbial hunters of south India.

Often when Krishna visits the ruins at Hampi, he feels a sense of wonder and awe at what happened here, and what this place must have been like in its glory days. At times, he just goes and sits on some of the higher rocks or by the riverside, lost in reflection. In this he finds a sense of peace and contentment, even happiness. I notice that it is early evening already. As I prepare to take his leave, a muezzin’s call to prayer comes wafting over the village rooftops.